

Preview Cincinnati 2026

TOURNAMENT	LEVEL	SURFACE	ALTITUDE	AS 2025	AS 2024	AS 2023	1ST SERVE POINTS	SERVICE HOLD
National Bank Open Mont... ▾	MASTERS 1000	Outdoor Hard	30	1,02	N/A	1,07	72%	79%
Cincinnati Open ▾	MASTERS 1000	Outdoor Hard	226	1,20	1,19	0,80	72%	80%
AVERAGE							71%	79%

Cincinnati has been one of the fastest surfaces on tour. This is mostly due to the surface itself, the high altitude and the hot weather here: 1.19 and 1.20 over the last two years, which will definitely be much faster than Montreal.

Now, it's always tricky because sometimes surfaces can change from year to year, as we saw this year with Montreal. So logically we should have fast and low-bouncing conditions this week, which favor first-strike tennis and aggressive, service-oriented tennis but we need to follow up now in the first days of the tournament to see what it gives in the day/evening sessions

Cincinnati can also be quite windy and is known for extreme heat, which poses an additional challenge. We've seen similar weather in Washington, where the heat caused issues for some players.

Last year Cincinnati and Shanghai were the trickiest tournaments of the year due to severe heat and high humidity: players collapsing on court, Sinner also retiring in the final, and a lot of upsets. So the weather is one of the most important factors to follow.

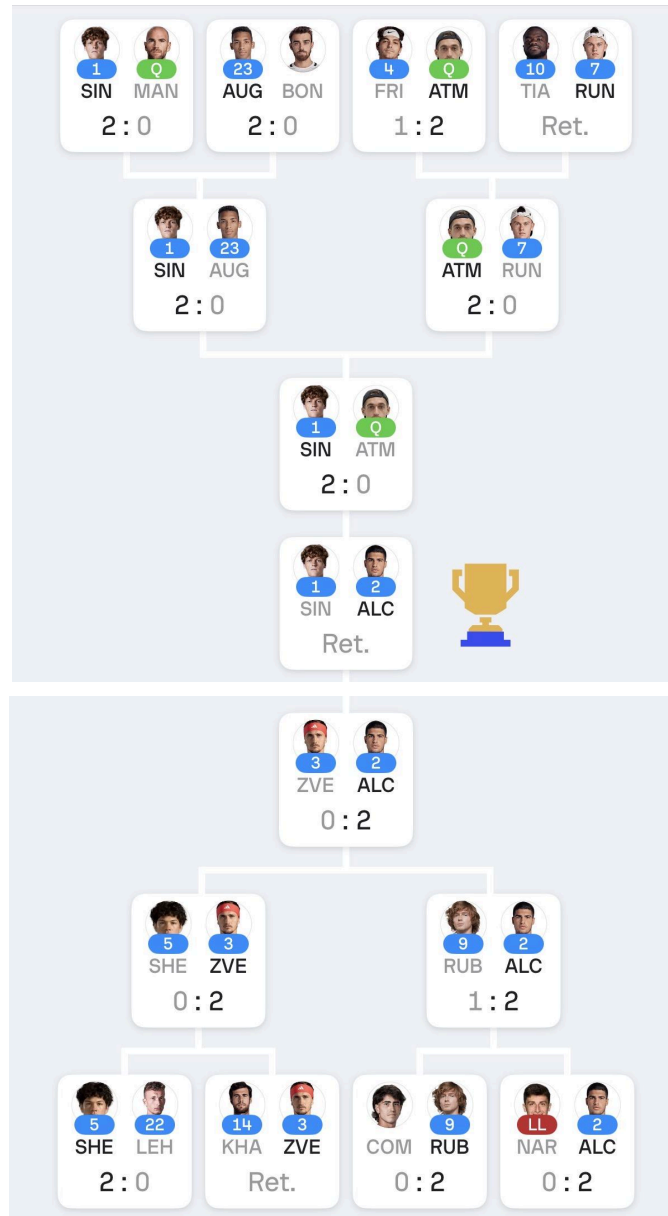
This is the last big tournament before the US Open. I would favor those who didn't go deep in Montreal given the short turnaround and rather lay or fade those who went deep in Montreal (and had some heavy legs already from Washington) once we're in the middle of the tournament.

Players want to peak for the US Open and I don't see a Nakashima or a Jodar continuing to go deep here after what they showed in Washington and Toronto.

Some players are also only arriving on the American hard-court swing now with Cincinnati, and they may need more time to adjust to the speed, heat and bounce. In contrast those who had some matches in Washington and Toronto will likely be better adapted to the weather conditions here.

All in all, we should normally have very quick conditions here with a medium-low bounce. On hotter days, this combination should favor first-strike tennis and big servers. We'll keep a close eye on the opening round to better understand the conditions.

Results - Cincinnati 2025



No Sinner and Alcaraz this week. The two semifinalists from last year are here, Zverev and Atmane. Atmane is playing for a lot this week: 400 points to defend, and if he doesn't, he will drop to around 100th place in the rankings, which would be a huge blow for him. For the rest, nothing important to highlight.

Weather - Cincinnati

TODAY 13/08	 30° 23°	A heavy thunderstorm  Night: Showers and a heavier t-storm	☁ 55%
FRI 14/08	 31° 22°	Sunny breaks, a thunderstorm  Mainly clear with a t-storm	☁ 55%
SAT 15/08	 33° 23°	Some sun, hot; a p.m. t-storm  Partly cloudy, warm and muggy	☁ 55%
SUN 16/08	 35° 22°	Sunshine, hot; a p.m. t-storm  A thunderstorm around early	☁ 55%
MON 17/08	 28° 18°	A stray morning thunderstorm  Partly cloudy and humid	☁ 55%
TUE 18/08	 28° 18°	Sunshine and less humid  Clear to partly cloudy	☁ 15%
WED 19/08	 29° 20°	Long periods of sunshine  Clear and humid	☁ 2%
THU 20/08	 30° 18°	Sunshine and very humid  Mainly clear and humid	☁ 5%
FRI 21/08	 32° 20°	Less humid with sunny spells  Mainly clear	☁ 2%
SAT 22/08	 31° 21°	An afternoon t-storm or two  A little rain in the evening	☁ 69%

The first stretch of the week is hot and stormy: 30–35°C from Thursday through Sunday, with thunderstorms possible every day (55% rain chance) and muggy, humid nights. This will lead to a lot of interruptions and different conditions during the day.

From Monday onwards it cools down and dries out significantly: 28–29°C with almost no rain risk and much less humidity by Tuesday and Wednesday. Conditions then heat up again slightly at the end of the tournament, with 30–32°C and humid air returning on Thursday and Friday, before a chance of afternoon storms at the weekend.

All in all, tricky conditions this week in Cincinnati: a lot of thunderstorms and rain in the next few days, while by the middle of next week we should have better conditions.

Information Healthy/Injured list (½)

Bellucci after his knee injury: "Physically I'm fine. I recovered in the last 4-5 days definitively. When we left we were absolutely not sure about playing, it was a matter of leaving to try to get into the best conditions to compete, to train with strong players and to try to speed up the return a bit. Obviously being away from matches for 5-6 weeks made itself felt a bit, but physically I'm fine. I had been without a racket for roughly three weeks, which is quite a lot.

Prizmic: returns to action in Cincinnati this week after being forced to retire with cramps in Umag last time out + low back problems

Fucsovics: shoulder problems since the start of the grass season.

Shapovalov on his last retirement: "I wasn't feeling good from the start. I've had this problem since the Los Cabos final and I've been in a lot of pain. Even today, during the warm-up, we didn't know if I was going to be able to play. We were trying to check how the ankle was responding. Even so, I wanted to make an effort for the fans. It's a very special tournament for me and I wanted to go out on court and give my best. I need to rest, recover from all the discomfort that appeared during the match, and I hope to be ready for Cincinnati. If not, we'll have to evaluate again what to do."

Collignon: played with a bandage on his left knee.

Arnaldi on his (other) foot injury : "The difficult thing for me isn't so much managing it, because if I do what I need to do, I don't feel pain. At Paris I played a lot and didn't feel too much discomfort. More than anything, I struggle with training, stopping, playing little, going to play and starting again. I need to play a lot of matches, to be on the court. When I stop, maybe I take one or two weeks where I train little and then I have to go on court, I find it harder. I'm someone who needs to be on court a lot and to be physically fit. When that's not there, I'm competitive, but maybe not at my 100%. The pain on the left started just before Wimbledon.

Draper, on his emotional loss in Montreal: "I don't get emotional often. There was once I got emotional in practice in May when I had really bad knee tendinitis and my arm was really sore as well. I was in so much pain. I was running and my knee [hurt] and my hitting the balls and my arm was sore. Last week came from a place of, I think I had so much to focus on and manage, so much change going on in my tennis. I got to [No]4 in the world through doing the same things, the consistent work, the differences, and then went through this whole process of a lot of setbacks and a lot of struggle. That's taken a lot out of me. But then at the same time, I'm in a position where I'm having to start again. That reality is difficult sometimes. The reason I got emotional was that through all the challenges, you can forget who you are on the court. And last week I felt like I couldn't give any more. I was emotional because I didn't recognise the player I was out on the court due to my injuries and due to probably the way I've been feeling for a long time. **(Nothing physical but rather emotions)**

Information Healthy/Injured list (2/2)

Berrettini, on his physical condition: "Unfortunately in the days before the tournament I felt a little discomfort and, as I said before the tournament, the key is accepting that this is how I am and that these things happen from time to time, especially when I stop for a bit, then start again, change surface, make long trips. It's a body that has been used a lot, so every now and then I get some discomfort that is harder to manage mentally than physically, because in the end I played my match. I never felt at my best on my serve, though the serve still did its job well enough. These things are hard to manage mentally, I know that and we know that, but I don't feel I can say I lost the match because of it."

Michelsen: has withdrawn from the doubles in Montreal with knee pain.

Machac: returns to action in Cincinnati this week after being forced to skip several events, including Stuttgart, Halle, Wimbledon and Montreal, with a left foot injury.

Kokkinakis: returns to action in Cincinnati this week after being forced to retire with a back injury in Montreal last week

Medjedovic: Already since more as month now he has 'virus problems' - Medjedovic took an MTO at 3-3 in the first set to have his vitals checked and looked physically limited for much of the match.

Buse: Loss of momentum for Buse since weeks now and took also an MTO in his last match for a right hip issue early in the second set.

Dimitrov, after his withdrawal from Los Cabos: "Unfortunately, here in Los Cabos, during a training session on Friday, I felt something uncomfortable in my leg that prevented me from training over the weekend. After medical tests, it has been confirmed that I have bursitis, so I have been advised that rest and recovery are the best option. I am very sorry for the tournament, as I was really looking forward to playing here with the incredible Mexican fans."

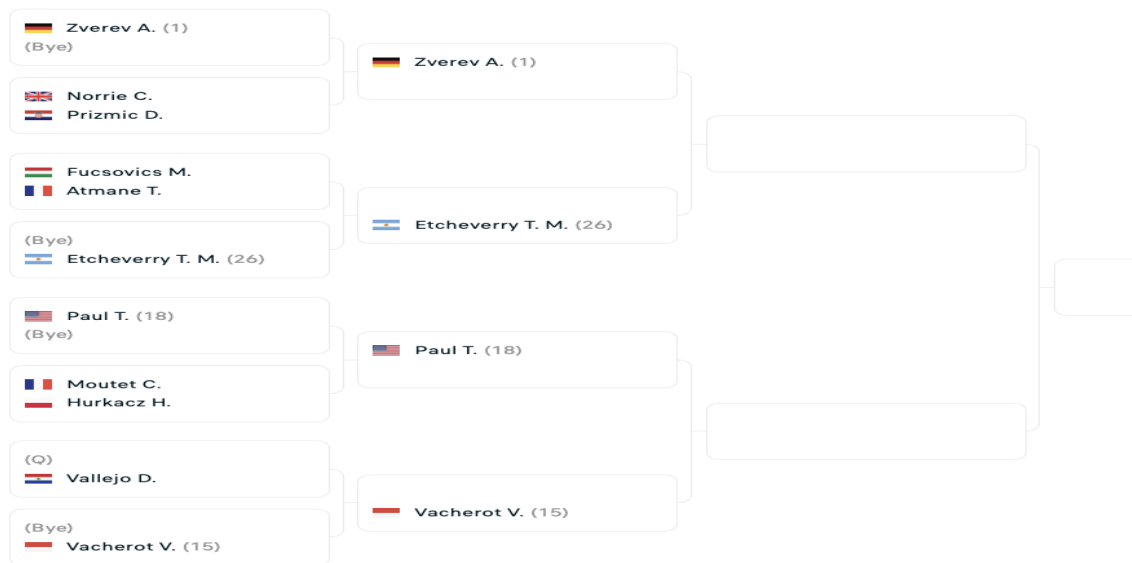
Sonego, on his wrist and current level: "I had wrist problems again at Wimbledon, then at Gstaad I carried it through, so I had to recover my wrist and I trained well physically those two weeks. I wanted to play Kitzbuhel but wasn't able to, so the important thing is that now I'm feeling good and playing. I've been training well these past few days. I think I'm maintaining a high level: already at Wimbledon and Gstaad I played good matches, and here too it was a good match.

Shang: had the physio out a game before the end for a left arm/elbow issue.

Tiafoe: has had a cyst surgically removed from his hand: "The doctors were able to diagnose and remove a cyst that had been causing me problems for some time. Everything went well. Thank you all for the messages and support. I'll be back soon."

FAA: "I started feeling pain on Monday. It was quite sudden. I had been training here for two weeks without any problems. It happens sometimes. It has happened before, but the timing is unfortunate. I tried to warm up and then I could barely serve. It was impossible for me to consider playing."

Quarter 1 - (1/2)



Favourite: Zverev

Dark Horse: Paul

Questionable: Fucsovics

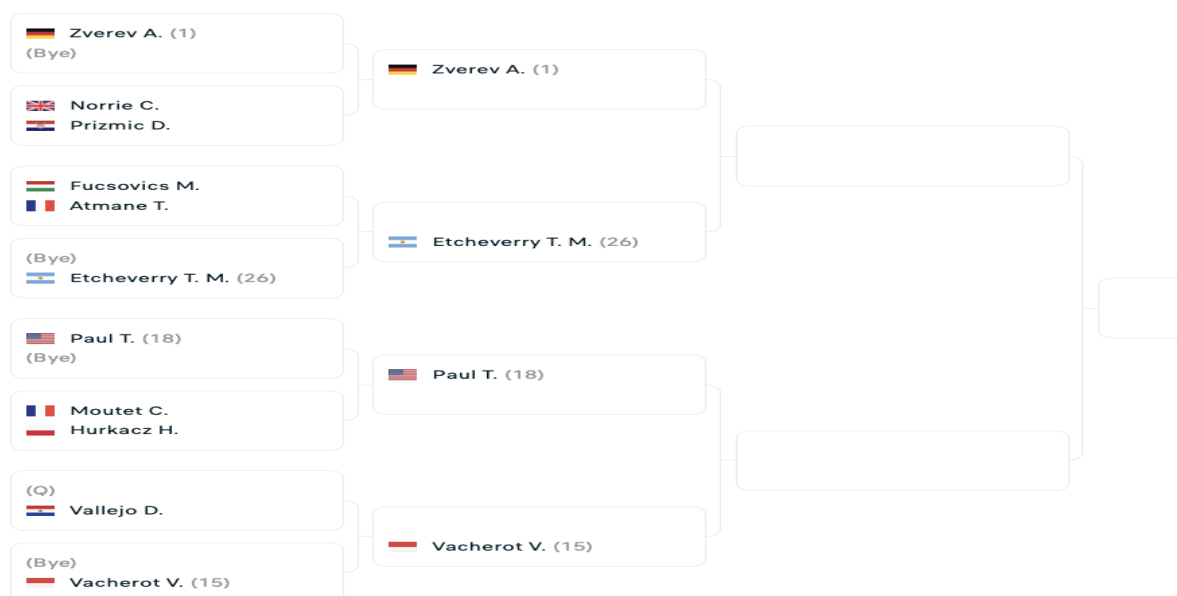
Zverev comes back here after an R1 loss in Montreal, his first early exit at a Masters 1000 this year. This is what he said after losing to Griekspoor: "I didn't expect to play well. I also didn't expect to play this bad, to be honest. I think this was probably the worst match of the season that I've had this year. I didn't have many bad matches, but this one was up there as the worst. But that's okay. It's a process."

He is 16–9 at Cincinnati with three semi-finals in a row, so it looks like he has been enjoying the conditions over the years. To be followed here, because with Alcaraz and Sinner not playing this week and not even certain to take part at the US Open, this is the perfect preparation for him. Quite of a decent draw until R4 for his first test against Paul/Hurkacz/Vacherot.

We saw a good Norrie last week in Montreal but the courts also suited him much better (it was the first time in Montreal that we really had such slow courts, and we saw a lot of clay-courtiers do well) a surface he kind of likes: slow, medium-bouncing and good for his game. He is 4–5 here, with his best run coming in his peak year on tour, a semifinal in 2022 where he beat Murray, Shelton and Alcaraz before losing to Coric in the semifinals. He was in much better shape back then, the Cincinnati courts have also become quite a bit faster over the years and in his last two appearances he exited in the first round both times.

Prizmic on the other side arrives here from Umag, where he retired during the match, apparently due to cramps, but at the event before that he was already complaining about his lower back, so that's something to follow. Difficult to predict here, Prizmic could definitely beat Norrie with the firepower he has but didn't had any preparation and we don't know where he is at the moment.

Quarter 1 - (1/2)



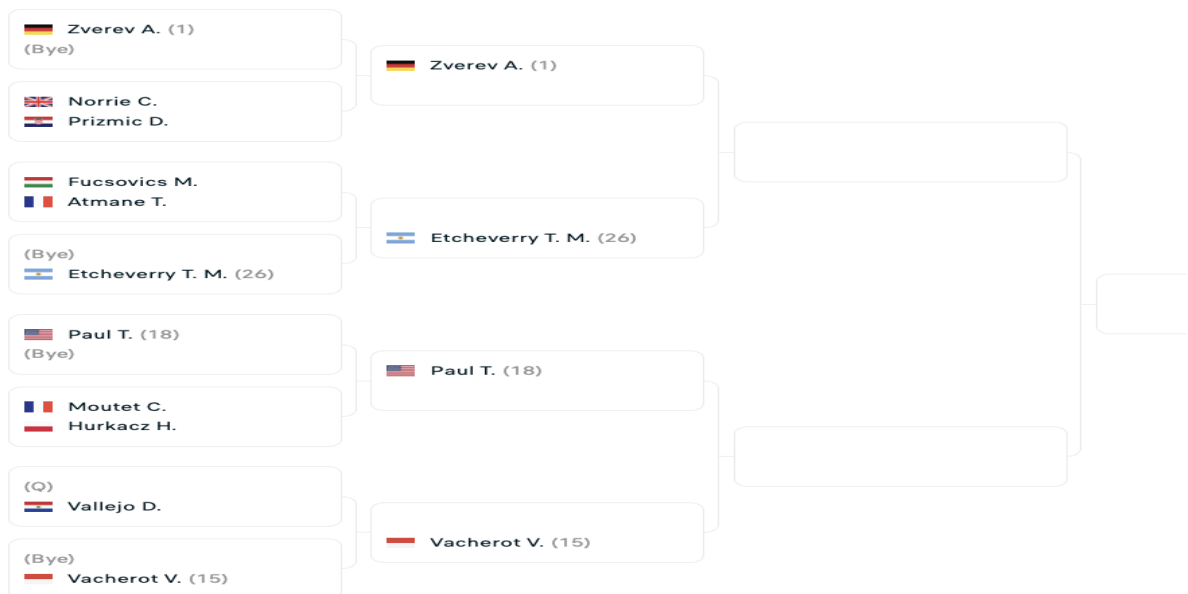
We saw it last week with Fucsovics that he is still not at his best. He has been carrying injuries (shoulder issues) with him since the grass season and literally got obliterated by Moutet. And now he will probably face the best version of Atmane, who is doing well on the North American hard courts, with a good level in Washington and a good level in Montreal, and who now has a semifinal to defend, which is huge for his ranking.

That's 400 points to defend, which could push him outside the top 100, so a lot is at stake for him. I would favor Atmane here given the better preparation, but we need to see how he handles the stress, because defending points can bring different emotions out of you. The conditions in Cincinnati are extremely favorable for Atmane's aggressive game. I believe that his motivation will be high, and I think he has really the upper hand here, as he said a match can change a life, and i'm sure that with what he has shown over the last weeks and how he has been playing in North America that we should see a good Atmane.

The winner will face Etcheverry, who is in bad form: he has won just 2 of his last 10 matches. Add to that his 2–3 record here over the years and few things are going his way. Now, he did have quite difficult matches at the start of the swing against Nakashima and Borges (a difficult matchup for him), so we can give him the benefit of the doubt but overall he's a player arriving here in poor form. A good spot potentially for Atmane if he wins his first match.

Paul arrives here far from his best form, an early exit in Washington and a genuinely poor performance against Tien in Montreal. Even the win before that (against Royer) was on small margins: he was hugely clutch, saving 8 of 9 break points. He also lost to Mannarino here last year. One to follow in the first round but at the moment there's no reason to be high on TP.

Quarter 1 - (1/2)



Hurkacz had an inexplicable choke: 40–15 up with two match points while serving for the match and still lost it. It was really shocking. Hurkacz is 8–7 at Cincinnati with a semifinal in 2023 and a quarterfinal in 2024, so it looks like the conditions suit him well, especially fast conditions like these. Since Moutet withdrew, we need to see who Hurkacz will play here, but he'll mostly be priced low, and I prefer Hurkacz as an underdog rather than backing him at these short prices where he always disappoints.

Vacherot comes here after a first-round exit against Navone in Montreal. He has lost some momentum since his injury. I found his matches before Navone not bad and even against Navone the first set was good but physically he got really worn down and ended up very erratic. Vacherot is a guy we can normally trust when it comes to physicality, so maybe it's just too early in the process but it's something to follow at the moment, and maybe he's better targeted against erratic players rather than against players who can keep the ball well in court like Navone did last week.

All in all, Zverev has a decent draw here. The only player I see possibly beating him is Paul, a high-peaking Paul which he is far from that level at the moment.

Quarter 1 - (2/2)



Favourite: Jodar & Cobolli

Dark Horse: Blockx & Collignon

Questionable: /

Jodar is arriving here after a defeat against Nakashima in the semifinals, and it proves once again that against good servers and solid baseliners, this is the kind of matchup he prefers the least, especially good servers who can find good spots. He was also quite physically gassed for me, and it wasn't really his day on return. All in all there are a lot of positives, but especially with such a short turnaround, I would be surprised to see him go very deep again this week. He is seeded so he has some time to adapt but we have very fast conditions here (different from Washington and Montreal last week) and we haven't seen him in very fast conditions where his return can be much less relevant. A player to follow to see how he adapts, but he'd rather be a fade for me this week, maybe against a high peaking Cobolli in R4.

He will face either Shapovalov or Mannarino, and yeah, what to say about Shapovalov? He retired in Canada, and this is what he said on 5 August about the decision to play: "I wasn't feeling good from the start. I've had this problem since the Los Cabos final and I've been in a lot of pain. Even today, during the warm-up, we didn't know if I was going to be able to play. We were trying to check how the ankle was responding. Even so, I wanted to make an effort for the fans. It's a very special tournament for me and I wanted to go out on court and give my best. Unfortunately, my body kept getting worse and ended up telling me I couldn't continue." So yeah, knowing Shapovalov and how volatile he is, I don't think there is any reason to back him, especially at such a low price. Mannarino arrives here with a loss in Washington against Michelsen and a loss in Montreal against Fearnley in less good conditions for him.

Quarter 1 - (2/2)



Last year he had a very solid tournament here in these faster conditions of Cincinnati, so I do expect him also to be much more competitive this week. I feel the current pricing isn't correct: Mannarino at 2.50, knowing that Shapovalov is very volatile, isn't a fan of counterpunchers and is coming back from an injury, makes me believe this is far from good pricing, and I'd rather be on Mannarino's value lines.

Tabilo arrives here in Cincinnati with a good Washington and a first-round loss in Montreal against Hurkacz. He has never done well here and has actually never won a match: he is 0–2 here over the years. Feels more like a player to fade for me, important to follow his first round.

Blockx played his first match after transitioning surfaces and it wasn't superb, and we have to say that he hasn't proven yet on the ATP Tour that he can be solid on hard, which he has proven on clay but not yet on hard. It was his first match after the transition, so we can still give him the benefit of the doubt. He has the game to do well on hard and will face a possible Belgian matchup in the next round. First game to follow here too

Navone beat Berrettini and Vacherot last week, mostly by pushing both players into errors, as neither had much firepower to hit through him in the slower conditions of Montreal (which I found quite surprising). Now here in Cincinnati, it may be much more difficult for him to make his excellent court coverage and point construction count. Collignon normally has the firepower to hit through him here, as he hits hard from both sides and can shorten points easily. Now, I'm a bit less convinced by Collignon's recent performances, as he hasn't played very well since his final in Gstaad. After that, he arrived exhausted in Kitzbühel, lost to Altmaier and lost in straight sets to Popyrin in Montreal last week.

Quarter 1 - (2/2)

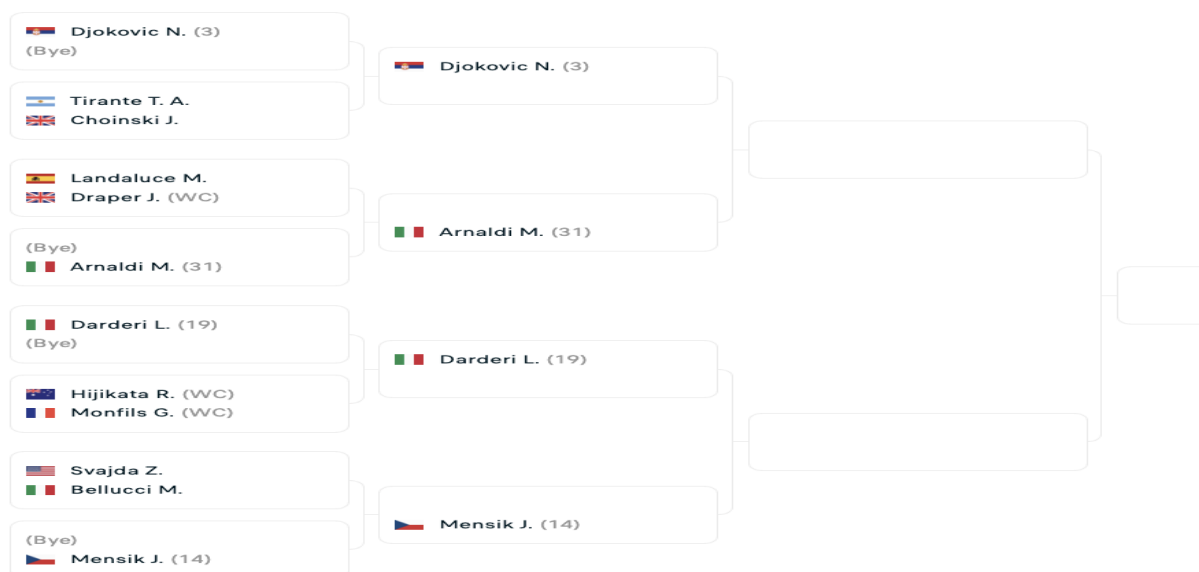


Cobolli, 5 August, after his loss to Hanfmann: "I think these have been difficult days. It rained a lot and it was hard to adjust for those coming from Europe; I think not everyone managed, or rather, some managed better than others. I believe I played the best practice sets of my life in these three days and had sensations I have rarely had this year, in a positive sense. So I was a bit surprised by the start of the match and by how it went, even though it can happen. The first match on hard courts, and it makes sense — sometimes you can't play the way you want. I've had this cough for three weeks that prevents me from breathing the way I want and recovering the way I want after a rally. I struggle to sleep and so I have this problem I can't resolve, but it's not an excuse and I don't want to diminish anyone."

So yeah, he said he felt superb in practice but wasn't able to show it on court in his first match after the transition. Interesting take, so if we have to believe him, we should see a much more locked-in Cobolli this week. In terms of record, he is 2–2 here over the years and lost to Atmane last year in the first round.

All in all, it will be important to follow Cobolli's first round to see which level he brings this week, as we know that when he reaches his maximum level he can be really dangerous. Jodar looks like a fade for me in this quarter but it will all depend on when. Blockx and Collignon are a bit the dark horses here but both not in the best form at the moment.

Quarter 2 - (1/2)



Favourite: Mensik

Dark Horse: /

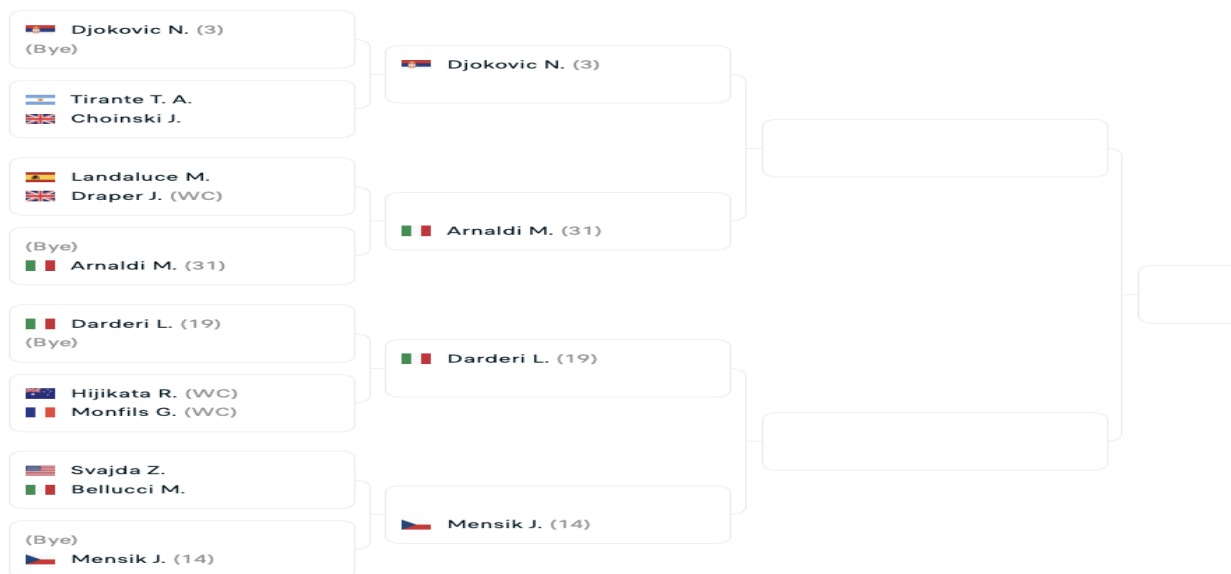
Questionable: Djokovic & Draper

Djokovic arrives here after Wimbledon without playing any preparation tournament and we know that the US Open is his main goal. Knowing that Carlitos and Sinner are not at 100% for the US Open and that they're not here without a preparation tournament, that should actually motivate him and make him see this as one last real chance. Now he was spot in his home country yesterday for his movie, so the big question is how well did he prepared the tournament? Cincinnati is his garden: the last four times he played it, he won it three times, but the most recent one was back in 2023. Not much to add. We'll see his first match, but we know this tournament will mainly be used to prepare himself for the US Open and I don't see him actually winning this at the moment. I would actually fade him this week.

We saw Draper crying in Montreal with all his desperation on his face but for me he didn't look that bad. I actually felt he played a correct match and he was up against a good opponent. Now yes, he hasn't played much and he doesn't look confident with his body but he has quite a good matchup here against Landaluce, especially since Landaluce can overhit quite quickly: 59 unforced errors against Mejia, and he's a player far from being in form.

The perfect match for Draper to kick his swing off with a win. I don't think he received a wildcard for the US Open, which means he'll have to play qualifying to enter the main draw. That's also an important point: I think if he goes deep here and shows he has a good level, he might have a big chance to receive it. So yeah, I believe we'll see a fully locked-in Draper, one to potentially fade later in the tournament, maybe against Djokovic or Mensik.

Quarter 2 - (1/2)



Arnaldi on his physical condition: "The difficult thing for me isn't so much managing it, because if I do what I need to do, I don't feel pain. At Paris I played a lot and didn't feel too much discomfort. More than anything, I struggle with training, stopping, playing little, going to play and starting again. I need to play a lot of matches, to be on the court. When I stop, maybe I take one or two weeks where I train little and then I have to go on court, I find it harder. I'm someone who needs to be on court a lot and to be physically fit."

After his loss to Griekspoor: "I'm happy. I played a good match, it was a tough fight. If I look at where I was last week, there are a lot of positives. Today was a really good match; I definitely lacked something, but I can't ask too much of my body. I've played little, I've trained little, so, as I said, there are a lot of positives. I'm leaving with a little more confidence and I'll play Cincinnati a bit more relaxed, if I can continue on this path."

So yeah, not really convincing for me with Arnaldi. Every tournament he keeps mentioning this foot injury and not feeling good about it, it's already three times he has mentioned it. He looks like a player to fade to me and that could be straight away in R2 if we see an XXL performance from Draper. To add to that, Arnaldi has never won a match here in three appearances.

Darderi after his loss to Nakashima: "It was a really positive week. Brandon is a very strong player. Today I didn't play my best tennis, but he played very well. He served very well at the important moments, so I can only compliment him. Now we have to go to Cincinnati and think about next week." On the match: "The conditions at night and during the day are not the same, but it's the same for both of us."

And that's a very interesting take, since it was already much faster there and here we'll have even faster conditions for Darderi. The conditions last week were good for him but I'm less of a fan of him this week. A player to fade for me, maybe in R3 against Mensik, who should like these conditions.

Quarter 2 - (1/2)



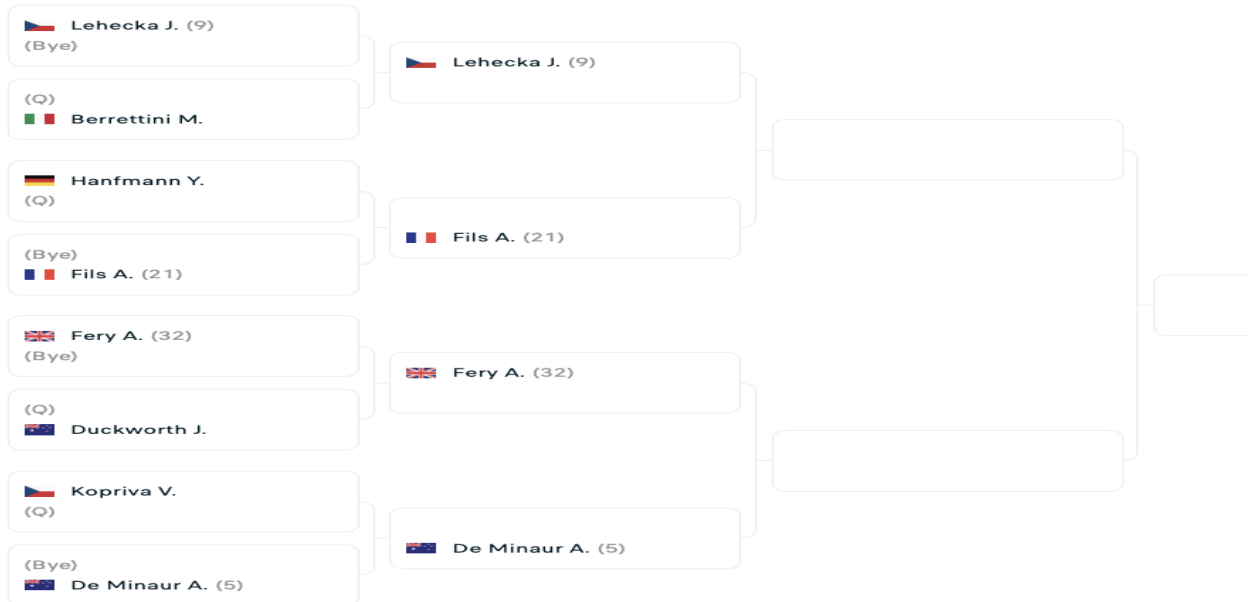
Monfils would have dogwalked opponents like this in his best years but now with the age it's much harder for him to confidently beat a baseliner/counterpuncher like Hijikata. Hijikata isn't in the best form either at the moment and has lost a bit of momentum since the grass season. Munar did defeat him last week by being very clutch, so I wouldn't say that Hijikata played a bad game. Monfils showed a good level last week and I hope he can build on it. He also received a wildcard for the US Open. Difficult to call a winner here because Hijikata could play counterpuncher/baseline tennis and could drag errors out of a possible erratic Monfils but overall i'm slightly higher on Monfils here.

Mensik: "Obviously I'm tall so especially on the hard courts where the surface is a little bit faster, usually it's bouncing low. Basically after the bounce it's still super fast. Obviously I'm happy. Since I was young, I was a tall guy with a big serve so that's a main pillar for my game. That's why I'm using it so often."

Even better now in these conditions. I wasn't a fan of Mensik last week in Montreal and that's why I laid him, but if he brings a good first round here he could definitely be a player I back later in the tournament. I'm high on him, I just want to see his W/UE this week and his first round, but R3 against Darderi looks like a good spot and R4 against Djokovic/Draper looks like an interesting spot too.

All in all, Mensik is the favourite here. If we get the fast conditions of last year (which should be similar to Miami, a tournament he's already won) we could ride Mensik for a couple of rounds. But the first round is important to follow, to see his stats and data: he can sometimes be quite error-prone. The current level of Djokovic and Draper are also question marks, so we need to follow their first-round data too.

Quarter 2 - (2/2)



Favourite: ADM, Fils & Lehecka

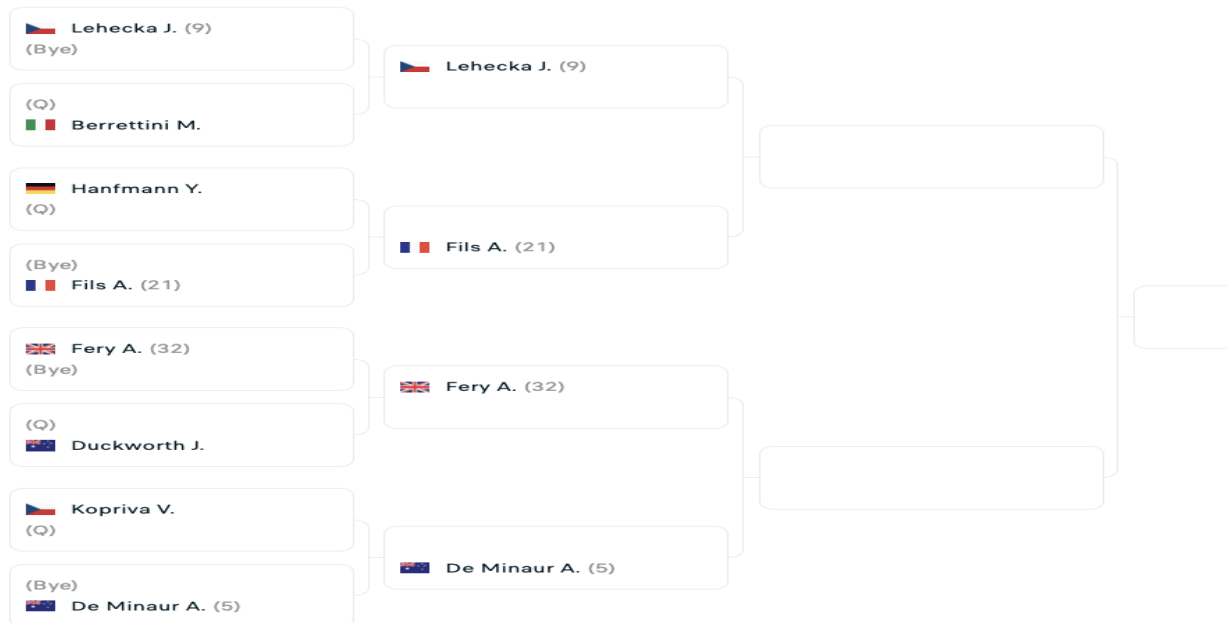
Dark Horse: /

Questionable: /

Lehecka after his loss to Jodar: "A tough result to take, but that's part of sport. We fought until the end and left everything on the court. Now it's about taking the lessons, putting in the work, and making sure we come back better than before." As said, I'm not convinced by Lehecka at the moment, especially since he got really obliterated by Jodar in the rallies and overall I still haven't been high on Lehecka since the start of the swing. Very interesting here with Berrettini possibly in R2, Fils in R3 and ADM in R4. So a very tough draw for Lehecka. He is 4–3 here over the years with a third round in the last two editions, losing to Shelton and Tiafoe. Very good conditions for him this week but still personally not convinced of his level

Much better conditions for Berrettini this week than last week in Montreal, as it was much slower there this year, but he is just 2–6 here over the years with three first-round losses in his last appearances (Rune, Auger, Tiafoe). It depends on his first round but I will probably not back him this week. He can be dangerous but I don't trust Berrettini body-wise right now. He also added this on his physical condition: "Unfortunately in the days before the tournament I felt a little discomfort and, as I said before the tournament, the key is accepting that this is how I am and that these things happen from time to time, especially when I stop for a bit, then start again, change surface, make long trips. It's a body that has been used a lot, so every now and then I get some discomfort that is harder to manage mentally than physically, because in the end I played my match. I never felt at my best on my serve, though the serve still did its job well enough." So yeah, I believe the conditions suit him well but there are few positive signs and I'm skeptical about his body language, would rather fade him this week

Quarter 2 - (2/2)



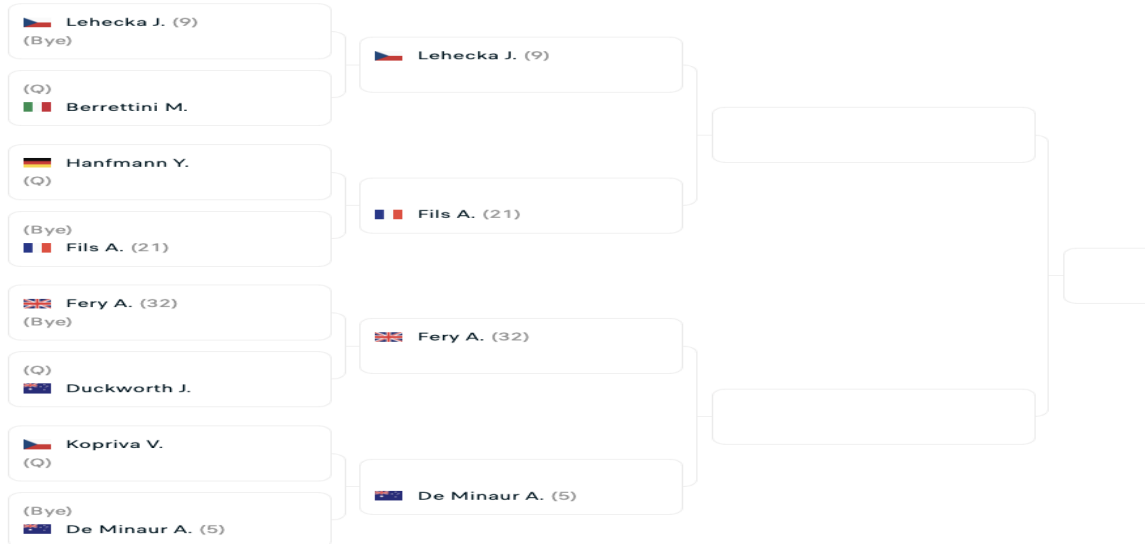
Fils, on his form: "It had been a while since I had chained several matches together competing at my best, without discomfort, and that boosts my confidence, as well as my tennis level. I feel that my backhand is working again and I'm improving every day. I'm very happy." He is building at the moment. He wasn't the cleanest on serve this week and was also quite error-prone but he faced good counterpunchers/returners.

I'm still a bit skeptical about Fils at the moment, especially body-wise and even more know with back to back Masters 1000 and US Open behind the door. To be seen how the conditions work out, but we have quick courts here in Cincinnati like in Miami, where he lost the semifinal against Lehecka, who took time away from him by being aggressive. His first round is one to follow, but I'd rather back him at the start of the tournament and fade him in the later rounds, big question marks for me bodywise.

I didn't find any information on why Fery hasn't played since Wimbledon; maybe he took some holidays (?) It's the first time he's seeded, which will be a new experience for him. Some of the names he defeated are Bu and Cobolli on hard this season, the rest rather at Challenger level. It's a surface transition and a first match, so it's very tricky here (as we saw with a lot of players last week) one to follow after his first match, as potentially facing Duckworth could already be a first test for him, since Duckworth can be tricky in fast conditions.

ADM on the double fault at match point: "I don't think that's quite it. I had other chances too. The end of the set was very tense, at 5:5 in the tiebreak. That double fault is just one point. Throughout the whole match I had plenty of chances. Of course I would like to take that double fault back, but that's tennis. These things happen: sometimes luck is on your side, sometimes it isn't." Of course I'm disappointed, but I'm already looking ahead and thinking about the next tournament."

Quarter 2 - (2/2)



This doesn't sound as dramatic as his press conferences after past losses; it looks like he's quite over it. In the last preview I believed ADM would do well because of the fast conditions, but we saw that it was slow in Montreal. Here in Cincinnati it should normally be faster, so I'll stick with it: I believe fast courts will help ADM much more, and even better, we might get him at a higher price after all the recent chokes. To be followed, I want to see his R2 first.

All in all, Lehecka has good conditions here but isn't in the best form. Fils showed a good level last week, but back-to-back Masters with the US Open just around the corner makes me skeptical. And ADM isn't in the best form either, but he finds conditions here that suit his game again.

Quarter 3 - (1/2)



Favourite: Fritz

Dark Horse: Fonseca, Ruud & Michelsen

Questionable:

Fritz took an MTO down 3–2 in the second set to receive treatment on his foot and looked to be physically struggling for much of the match. He was far off the level he showed in Washington and clearly appeared physically limited due to the knee tendinitis, fatigue and the foot problem on the day. added this: "I'm in a much better place to be ready to play here. I shouldn't have, I think it's fine for me to want to try and play in Montreal, but after the first set of that match, I probably should have just shook hands. My body wasn't just right. And it was tough to go from DC and then just play a day later. I felt great playing throughout DC, but then it just felt like after, mentally I knew that the tournament was done, my body felt like it kind of just hit a wall." He is 9–8 here and has never passed the quarterfinals, losing to Atmane in R4 last year. Good conditions for him and it will be less physical (depending on the weather too), but he already has a tricky first round, probably against Michelsen, so this match will give us already the answers we want. He says that he feels ready, but always keep in mind it's the US Open after this and at any moment if he feels something he could just retire/withdraw to not take any risks for the us open/

Michelsen, who has played a lot of tennis since Wimbledon withdrew the day before his loss against Merida from doubles with knee pain, so yeah, it's quite tricky here. Good conditions for him this week too, as he is a good server and returner and has had a good preparation. He should normally just win the first round here and then we have the match-up against Fritz but a lot depends on how bad his knee pain is.

Quarter 3 - (1/2)



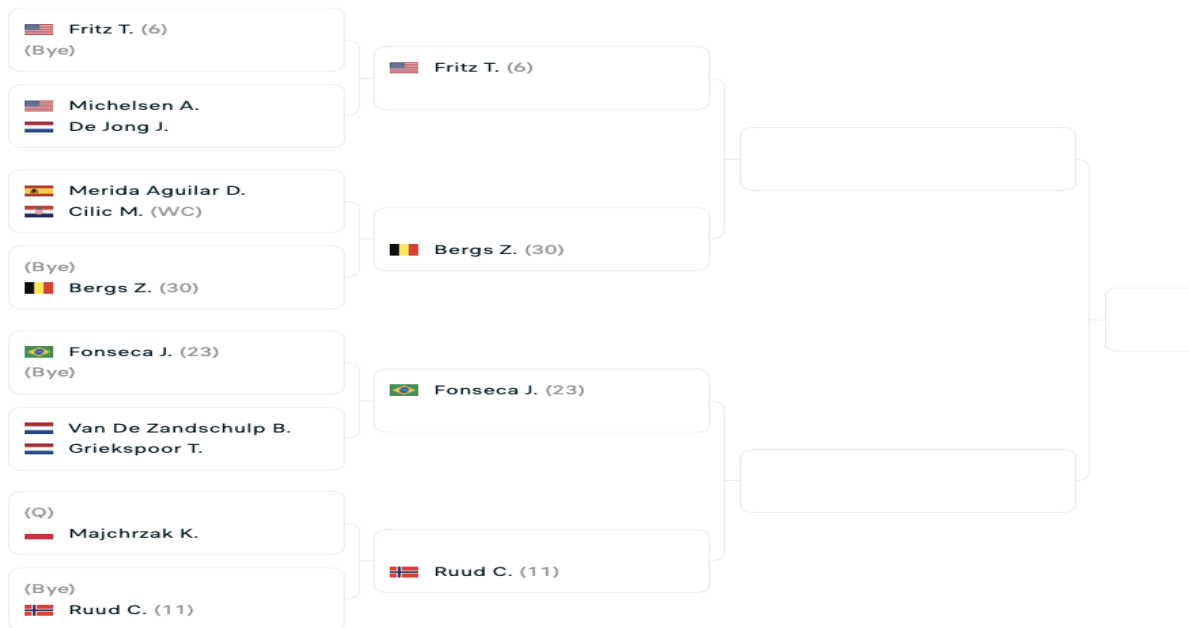
Merida: "It's been an amazing week. I came into the tournament determined to give 100% in every match. Winning my first title three weeks ago gave me confidence, and I knew that if I kept fighting until the end of every match, I'd have opportunities against these players and could make a run here."

If I'm not wrong, it was his first ATP main-draw win of the season on hard, and he will now be in totally different conditions than last week. Montreal really benefited his game well, here it will be different and even more so against a good attacking baseliner like Cilic who will take time away from him. Cilic loves the conditions in Cincinnati and has already been champion of the tournament. Slightly higher on Cilic here.

Bergs: still not too high on him at the moment. Now he is two events further along, has had more time to practise and should love the Cincinnati vibe, as he's a player who also likes the atmosphere around the tournament, but his first serve has been in real distress and he has been so error-prone. He's a player who needs match rhythm, which he doesn't have at the moment. It will finally be important for him to drag some wins together. R2 is doable, with an R3 against Fritz/Michelsen, which are not good matchups for him. More a player to fade for me.

Fonseca after his loss to Shelton: "It's difficult to assess the defeat. I'm only thinking about resting and preparing for Cincinnati. I hope to improve my tennis there. I feel like I didn't do things well on the return, I didn't create the necessary opportunities and I come away with the feeling that I played badly. I definitely need to improve. I failed on the important points, I didn't put the necessary pressure on him and on the serve I was far from the consistency needed. The serve decided everything. Shelton deserved to win and I can only keep working." Now, if we see the level of Shelton this week, we can say it was a good first preparation tournament for Fonseca, who did defeat Tsitsipas and Ruud, so he can build on that. He might face Ruud again in R3. I want to see his R2 to see how he plays before deciding whether to lay or back him.

Quarter 3 - (1/2)



VDZ, after losing to Mensik: "The difference came down to a few key points. At 5-4 there were a couple of long rallies that just went his way, and maybe I didn't get one or two free points on serve that he was able to rely on. That was probably the biggest difference today."

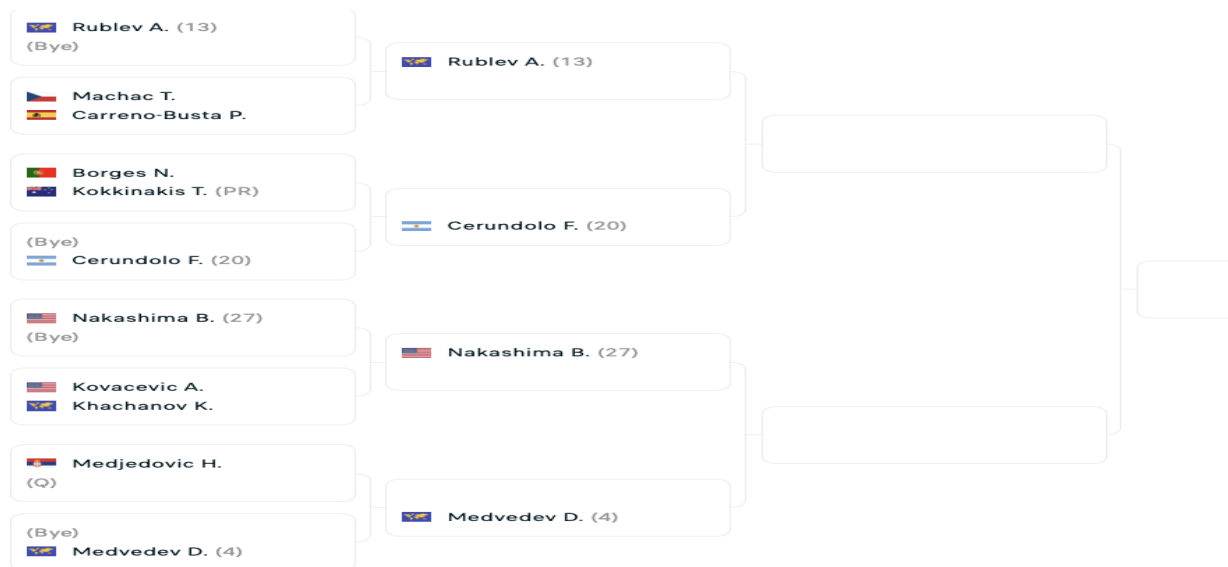
I wouldn't be surprised if we see a VDZ here who just gets an early exit out of nowhere. Yes, his level was solid last week but we just can't rely on him in the early rounds of tournaments like this.

He will face his compatriot Griekspoor, who said a couple of days ago that he was almost taking a break: "I don't mean I was ready to retire, but I did think about taking a break. At this stage of my career you naturally start thinking about what else you want in life. When you're going through a difficult period and the enjoyment disappears, those thoughts come more often." On his motivation: "I still don't think I've reached my full potential." Griekspoor was very error-prone in his last two matches, and when VDZ is locked in and counterpunches him, he could drag a lot of errors out of his game. A match to skip, could literally go both way.

And finally Ruud. For me he really got impacted by the slower night conditions and could not hit through Fonseca at all. The conditions here should help him get some speed on the forehand and serve, but overall I'm not convinced yet by Ruud. As said, he now really has that tag of being a player who is less involved in tennis, and it feels like his work ethic is also just less locked in, while the new generation with real firepower in the arm blows him off the court. An interesting stat: he is 2-6 here over the years with four first-round losses at Cincinnati. Needs to be followed up, but it doesn't look really positive.

All in all, Fritz, Fonseca, Michelsen or Ruud should take this quarter. Important to follow the R2s of Fonseca and Ruud to see which lines we get and whether there is something interesting to take.

Quarter 3 - (2/2)



Favourite:

Dark Horse:

Questionable:

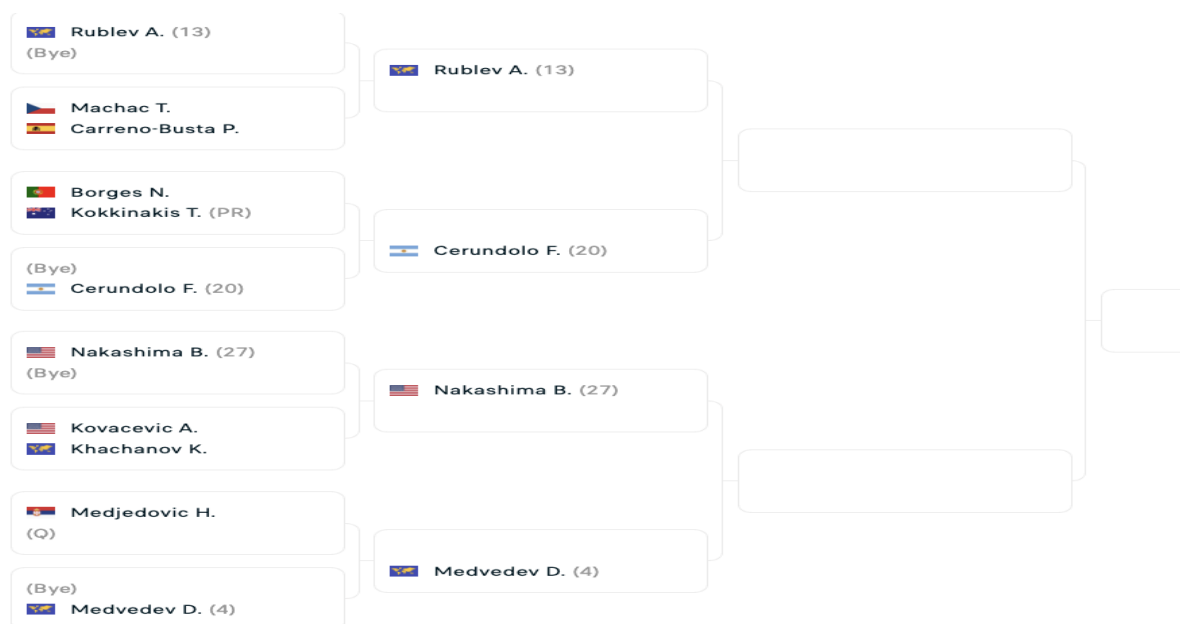
Rublev: "There was no difficulty in anything. I lost this match myself. There were all the chances, there were plenty of match points, it just didn't work out. On the match points I did everything right: either a small out, or something else, or he played a lucky shot. When it's a match like this, there's nothing to say. Out of 10 such matches you win nine. It happens. You need to move on."

Khachanov, Rublev and Medvedev are all in the same bracket and are just not reliable at this point. The conditions in Montreal were perfect for him but he choked it away and I feel that the mid-gen of the nineties chokes more and more. He will face either Machac or Carreno Busta. For the moment it is better to just stay away from Rublev.

Machac always seems to have some kind of problem, whether it's physical or, more often than not, something else. You never know what to expect from him, especially in the early rounds. He hasn't played for three months now, add the hot weather to that, or even the interruptions and there's simply no need to bet on him at the moment, better to just follow or avoid this part of the draw with Rublev and Machac, who is so unpredictable. It could literally go all sides

Borges is in a good form at the moment and since Roland Garros but once again a matchup where his time is taken away, that's what he clearly hates. Kokkinakis on the other side had to retire once again against Popyrin in Montreal, apparently for a back problem. It's difficult to gauge why he is already here again. I think he can really challenge Borges if he is at 100%, since it's a decent matchup for him. Borges has the form but Kokkinakis is very dangerous and unpredictable here. Game to avoid or see the body language of Kokkinakis and fade him on retirement lines

Quarter 3 - (2/2)



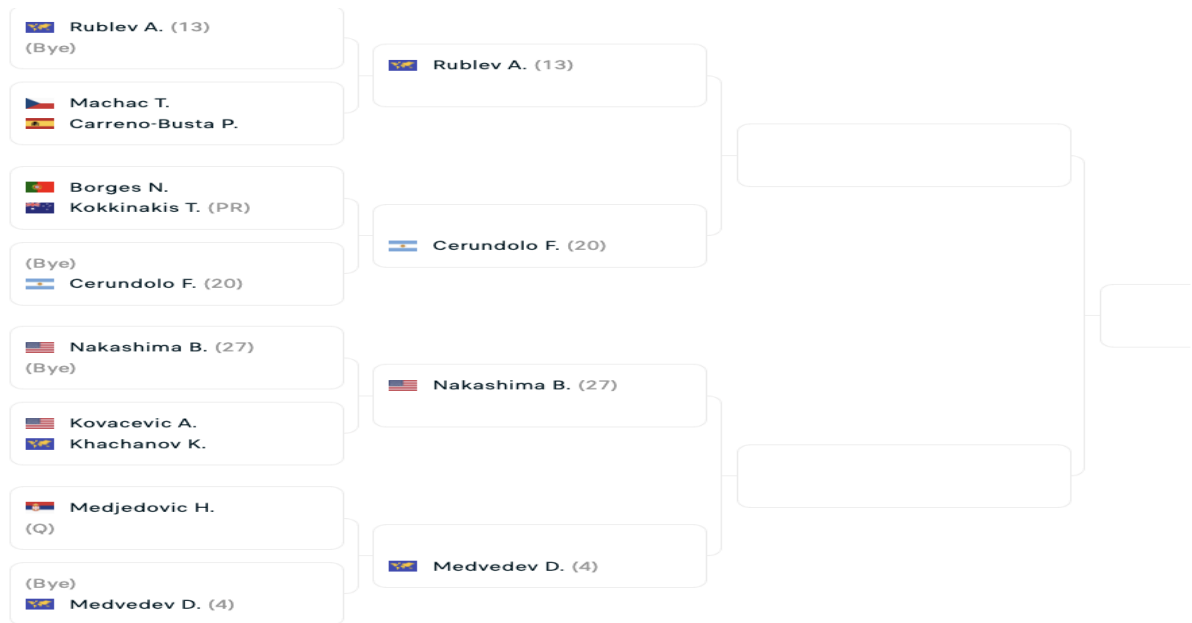
31 unforced errors in two sets for Cerundolo and since his title in Queen's he hasn't won an official match in two sets. He is 0–3 here at Cincinnati and has never won a match, so there is literally no reason to be high on Cerundolo at the moment. As said the upper part of this draw is just too unpredictable

Nakashima said: "Overall, my body has been feeling pretty good these last few weeks. Obviously it has been a lot of matches and a lot of tennis for me. There is some soreness here and there and some days I can feel a little tired, but overall my body is feeling pretty good. I am feeling good on court, I am moving well, and now I just have to focus on a couple more matches."

At the moment I'm writing this, he is in the final of Montreal and has literally played the best match of his career. I've never seen Nakashima play like this, so hats off. At some point there should be a setback in his results but do you want to fade a player who is in full momentum? I wouldn't at the moment. Now, Khachanov in R2 could already be a tricky spot for Nakashima, knowing it's the only tournament of the year where there is such a short turnaround with another Masters. They still need to play the final while R1 starts here today. I'm very curious to see the opening lines here if Khachanov wins.

Kovacevic can keep matches close simply by holding his serve but he is also not in good form at the moment and is quite error-prone, with 45 unforced errors and mostly an unreliable backhand when he is not playing well. The same goes for Khachanov, who is becoming more and more just a normal player and has lost his clutchness/difficulty to beat. These are good conditions for him and a decent matchup and even if I'm not high on Khachanov, my gut feeling tells me that Khachanov should win here.

Quarter 3 - (2/2)



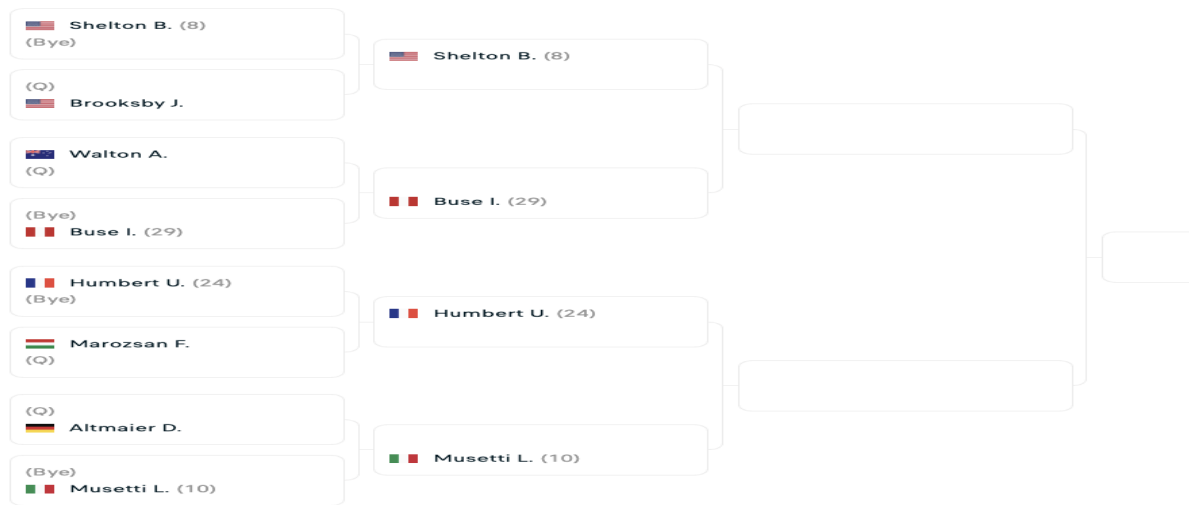
Medjedovic took an MTO at 3–3 in the first set to have his vitals checked and looked physically limited for much of the match against Cerundolo. I don't know what he has had recently, but he had a virus during or after Wimbledon which made him withdraw from tournaments, so we have a very volatile Medjedovic at the moment. So yeah, to be followed up, but I wouldn't advise betting on him given he was about to retire last week.

Medvedev, after his loss to Van de Zandschulp: "It was a catastrophic match, probably one of the worst of my career. I don't think I've ever lost six service games in two sets on hard courts, so it was a real disaster. There's no explanation. I had trained well though. Nothing can be done about it now. All I can do is move on."

As he says himself, there's no explanation, which for us as bettors means we either lay him or stay completely away from him. The courts in Montreal were slow, and once the courts aren't how he wants them, it doesn't work. Medvedev is just so matchup-dependent, untrustworthy for me and really one to avoid. He can exit early or go deep and win a tournament. As said last week, he is now 1–5 in the last three years in this swing.

All in all, this draw can go in all directions with so many highly volatile players. Nakashima is a player to fade for me this week, depending on how short his turnaround is. For now it's way too early to say who could take this part of the quarter, as it's all just too unpredictable, especially the three Russians: Khachanov, Rublev and Medvedev.

Quarter 4 - (1/2)



Favourite: Shelton

Dark Horse: Musetti

Questionable: /

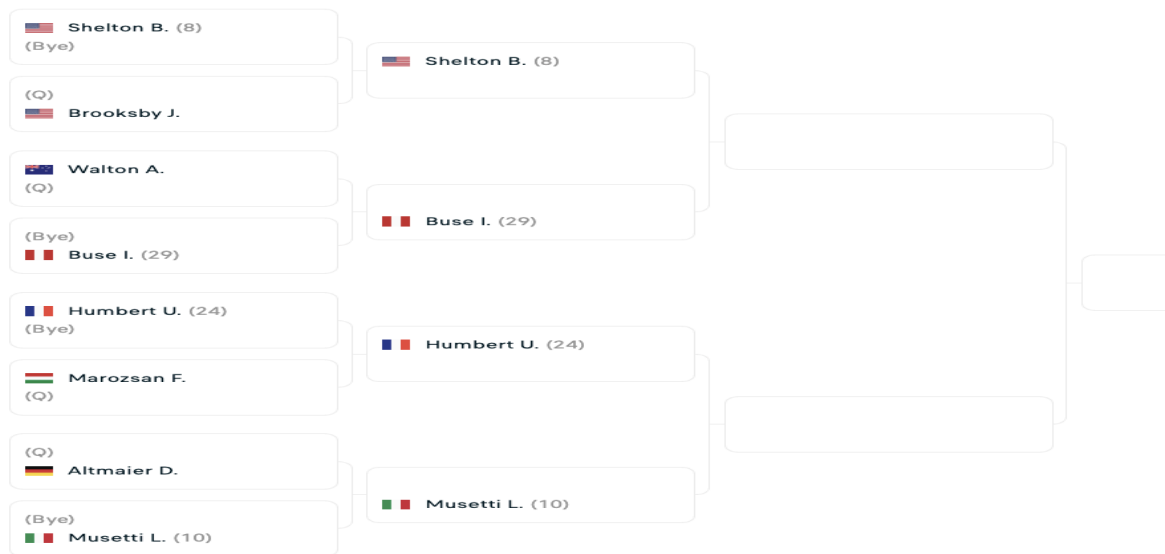
A solid level from Shelton this week, and I won't repeat everything I already said in the analysis. I'd rather focus on the same run as last year: he won Montreal, came to Cincinnati, defeated Carabelli, Lehecka and Bautista, and then lost to Zverev where he was completely burned out. So after four rounds he was really burned out. I'm more of a fan of fading Nakashima than Shelton for physical reasons. Shelton hasn't had the most physical year (compared to last year) and missed parts of the season where he had early exits but with Shelton I would rather ride his momentum if we get a good matchup. Now, the conditions are quicker here and as he says himself, the slower, high-bouncing conditions are the best for him and the balls in Montreal were superb for his game (his own words). So it's interesting to follow his first match of the week to see how he has adapted, player to back for me this week.

He might have a rematch against Brooksby in round two, who can always be tricky in these conditions. That's why we need to follow it to see how Shelton adapts and whether we keep riding his momentum on this surface or not. But he really isn't a player I believe will check out physically (compared to Jodar or Nakashima).

For Buse, same principle as last week: a player to fade for me. Since the grass season (mostly Mallorca) we've seen him at a lower level, he isn't at his best physically, and he once again took an MTO for a right hip issue early in the second set. He also hasn't proven anything yet on hard this season. A player to fade for me, and maybe Walton could be interesting: Walton had a decent run last year, defeating Navone and Medvedev before losing to Lehecka in a tight match.

All in all, if we check this upper part of the draw, it's a decent draw for Shelton, and even the lower part isn't the most challenging one.

Quarter 4 - (1/2)



I said it last week, and it's been the case for a couple of months now: Humbert is overrated on outdoor hard and he keeps having early exits. Now, to give him some benefit of the doubt this week, these are good conditions for him, probably the best he gets on outdoor hard courts, but when I look at his record here in Cincinnati he is 2–5. So yeah, not in the best form, quite overrated on outdoor hard and a poor record here. The only advantage he has are the conditions.

He will face Marozsan or a qualifier. I didn't like Marozsan's level much last week: he was also coming back from an injury and was very error-prone, and we know that when he isn't at his best he can start spraying errors very quickly. It depends what we see from him in the first round, but I'll probably not touch this match in R2.

Musetti, after his loss to Jodar: "I had an excellent chance that I wasn't able to take advantage of — that forehand that went long at 0-30 that could have given me three break points. I had two break points: on one he served well, on the other I made the mistake on the return, and he hadn't even served that well. These missed opportunities, these trains I didn't catch, sum it all up; I feel like I'm often living through the same sensations. Obviously it hurts, because I think I actually played better than the last time, but he certainly played better than his last performance."

And yes, I remember that chance very well, where he missed an easy forehand he would never normally miss, with three break points to take the break and serve for the set. Overall he was good in the first set but faded away physically, and the matchup just wasn't good for him. We know with Lorenzo that whenever he faces someone who takes time away from him, even more so when he isn't at his peak, that's where he has more difficulties. For me he will keep building form, but the fast conditions here are not to his advantage. I'd rather fade him this week. That might be against Shelton in R4 if we get that matchup.

Quarter 4 - (2/2)



Favourite: /

Dark Horse: Rinderknech

Questionable: Tien, Tiafoe & FAA

I wasn't impressed by Tien in Montreal. Add the strap on his arm and the cramps he had at the end of the match against Monfils, and for me Tien is physically not at his peak, maybe he's paying for his long season last year? What's certain is that I'll be trying to fade him this week, which would probably come in R4, not before. He lost in the second round here against Rublev last year. He will face the winner of Baez–Dimitrov.

Dimitrov comes back from a month without tennis. He had a good Wimbledon and returns on a fast surface. He withdrew from Los Cabos and said: "Unfortunately, here in Los Cabos, during a training session on Friday, I felt something uncomfortable in my leg that prevented me from training over the weekend. After medical tests, it has been confirmed that I have bursitis." Now, this year he is 2–6 on hard, with first-round exits in his last three appearances here at Cincinnati, so yeah, it's difficult to trust him at the moment. Even the fast conditions on hard this year haven't helped him much. Now, personally I think he should still win this.

He had a good preparation at Wimbledon and played good tennis, I guess he arrived here early, and it will all depend on how sharp he is. I think the fast conditions help him given where he is this year. Now, it's a first round, and his last three events at Cincinnati ended in first-round exits against Marozsan, Shapovalov and Zverev. So yeah, I want to give him the benefit of the doubt, but I wouldn't bet on him since he has no preparation on the surface, he is very volatile, and he has only won two matches on hard this season (against Atmane and PCB).

Quarter 4 - (2/2)



Shang finally played three matches. It's a good tournament and a good build-up for me but it's not like I trust him at the moment, I need to see more. He likes it when it's fast, so the conditions should be good for him here: faster conditions mean fewer long points. Now, the hot weather of Cincinnati could be a problem for him since he is quite fragile.

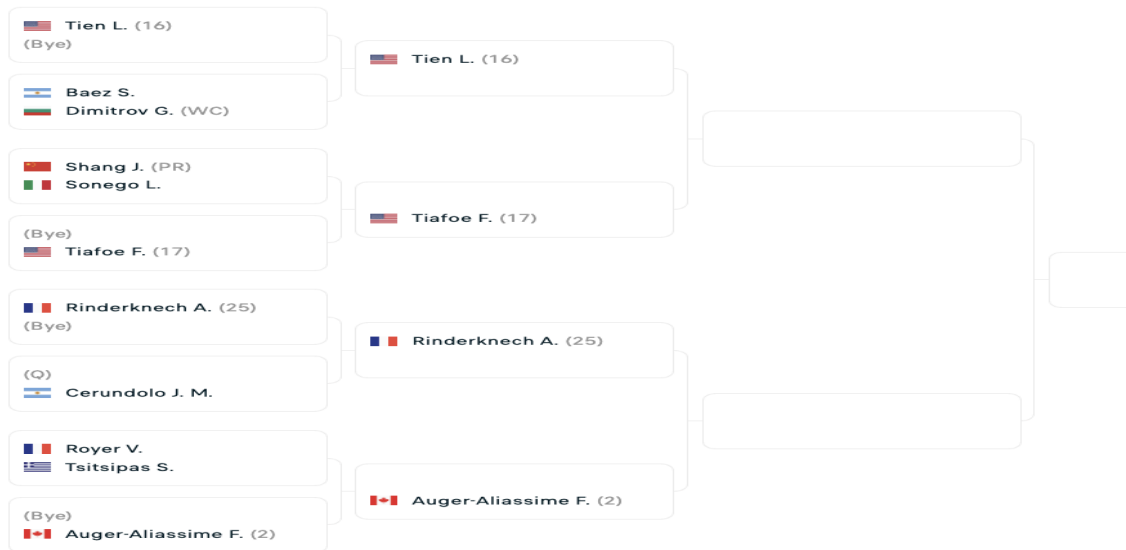
He will face Sonego, who is also still not at his peak form (far from it) and added: "I had wrist problems again at Wimbledon, then at Gstaad I carried it through, so I had to recover my wrist and I trained well physically those two weeks. I wanted to play Kitzbuhel but wasn't able to, so the important thing is that now I'm feeling good and playing. I've been training well these past few days."

The fast conditions could help him be less erratic, and I don't agree with Shang being priced so low, especially given that he has always been a player who is shaky physically, add the hot weather and back to back Masters 1000. It should be much closer for me.

Tiafoe, 8 August: he has had a cyst surgically removed from his hand: "The doctors were able to diagnose and remove a cyst that had been causing me problems for some time. Everything went well. Thank you all for the messages and support. I'll be back soon."

So five days later he is back in the main draw of Cincinnati (???) To add some context, Tiafoe is mostly a player who doesn't do well at the start of the season in order to actually peak for this part of the season, where he is mostly good: Cincinnati and the US Open are his most preferred tournaments. Here I don't believe he is healthy and think he is rather pushing to play his preferred tournaments. For me he is clearly a player to fade. Sadly, he is in the same draw as another player I want to fade, which is Tien.

Quarter 4 - (2/2)



I liked Rinderknech's level last week in Washington and these are good courts for his first-strike tennis (much better as last week) He's a player I want to back this week and maybe there could be some value lines against FAA in R3. Last year he defeated Ruud and Borges before retiring against FAA (due to the hot weather).

I'm sure that Royer could be a terrible matchup for Stefanos Tsitsipas (which we saw at Wimbledon): an attacking baseliner who could rush Tsitsipas in fast conditions, which is just horrible for Stefanos. But Royer isn't in good form. As for Tsitsipas, he won his title in Gstaad but has had two first-round exits since then. Both his match against ADM in Washington and his match against Fonseca in Montreal ended up being rather bad. So yeah, fast conditions for him now in Cincinnati, where he has already reached a final over the years, and that could help him finish points more quickly and dictate with his serve, plus-one patterns and forehand. To be followed.

Auger-Aliassime has withdrawn from singles in Montreal with a lower back injury sustained in practice: "I started feeling pain on Monday. It was quite sudden. I had been training here for two weeks without any problems. It happens sometimes. It has happened before, but the timing is unfortunate, that it happens here. I was lucky to have one more day to prepare (with the rain delay). I thought things would improve day by day, but I tried to go on the court today (Wednesday). I tried to warm up and then I could barely serve. It was impossible for me to consider playing."

That's what he stated. He also has no coach anymore, no preparation, and he needs to defend his US Open semifinal in two weeks. Not convinced by FAA at the moment and I'd rather fade him this week, depending on what I see in his first match.

All in all, Tien and Tiafoe are players to fade for me this week. FAA is a question mark, and Rinderknech could be a player I back this week. We need to watch their first matches before taking any direction.